The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Russia carried out a major bombing campaign against **Ukraine**, launching a total of 151 missiles and drones overnight. The strikes targeted energy infrastructure located in and around the cities of Kharkiv, Zaporizhia and Kryvyi Rih. Ukraine's energy minister, German Galuschenko, said the attacks were intended "to cause a large-scale failure in the operation of the country's energy system". On Wednesday Vladimir Putin had threatened to target the country's infrastructure in retaliation against recent Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries deep inside Russia.

The Biden administration lodged its first antitrust case against **Apple**. America's government accused the tech giant of using its dominant position in the smartphone market to hamper the development of third-party apps, messaging services and payment systems. Apple said the case is "wrong on the facts and the law".

American officials said they will bring a resolution calling for an immediate truce in **Gaza** to a vote at the UN Security Council. It proposes a six-week ceasefire and the release of 40 Israeli hostages in return for hundreds of imprisoned Palestinians. America's secretary of state, Antony Blinken, arrived in Israel on Friday amid rising tensions between the two countries.

India's Aam Aadmi Party called for nationwide protests after its leader and **Delhi's** chief minister, Arvind Kejriwal, was arrested on corruption charges by the country's financial-crime agency. The Enforcement Directorate, which is under the control of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party, is investigating several AAP leaders for allegedly taking kickbacks from an alcohol-licensing policy. Mr Kejriwal is challenging his arrest in a Delhi court.

Consumer prices in **Japan** rose by 2.8% in February compared with a year earlier, the fastest pace in four months. In January they rose by 2.2%. But a measure of inflation that excludes food and energy prices, the “core core” index, rose by only 3.2%, down from 3.5%. Japan ended its policy of negative interest rates earlier this week.

The EU’s 27 member states agreed to open accession talks with **Bosnia and Herzegovina**. Last week the European Commission said negotiations could begin because the west Balkan country had made sufficient strides in aligning with the bloc’s standards. Charles Michel, the president of the European Council, called it a “key step forward” on the country’s “EU path”.

Shares in **FedEx** rose by 13% after the parcel-delivery firm reported an increase in operating margins. A decline in business from America’s postal service, FedEx’s biggest customer, has hurt the company. But its margin was lifted by cost-cutting measures.

Figure of the day: 2.4%. The percentage of Dutch adults who said they had used cocaine in the last year, according to a 2022 study. Read the full story.

Photo: AP

Trump’s paper windfall

After he was booted off Twitter (now X) and Facebook after the Capitol riot of January 6th 2021, Donald Trump started his own social-media platform. Truth Social was to be a home for “censored” voices, although it never took off beyond the MAGA crowd. It also loses money hand over fist. Regardless, it is now poised to go public. On Friday investors in a special-purpose acquisition company—essentially a listed pot of capital—will vote on whether to merge with Truth Social’s parent company. The combined entity will have a market capitalisation of about $6.3bn.

Wonderful news for Mr Trump, whose stake will be worth $4.1bn. The paper windfall will be of no help in his current predicament, however, since he cannot sell his shares for six months. By March 25th he must secure a bond for half-a-billion dollars to satisfy a judgment in his civil-fraud trial. No bond company will step up since he lacks enough cash as collateral. So he is begging an appeals court to reduce the bond.

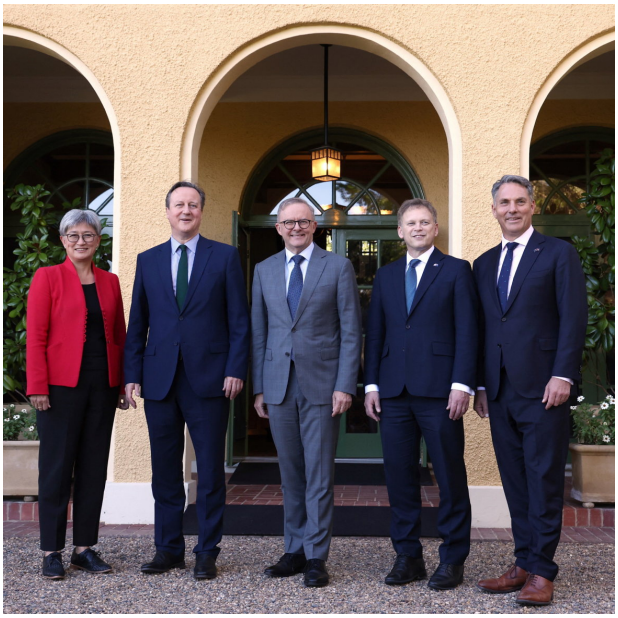


Photo: Getty Images

Britain and Australia boost their defence ties

David Cameron and Grant Shapps, Britain's foreign and defence secretaries, met their Australian counterparts, Penny Wong and Richard Marles, in Adelaide on Friday for security talks. On Thursday the two nations signed a defence co-operation agreement that makes it easier for their forces to operate in each other's countries.

Australia announced a huge investment in AUKUS, a trilateral security pact with America. Under the pact Britain and Australia aim to manufacture nuclear-propelled submarines for Australia. Australia will pump A$4.6bn ($3bn) into a British factory that will produce the subs' nuclear reactors.

Britain shares Australia's concerns about China's military buildup, and in an "Indo-Pacific tilt" has tried to boost trade with the region. However, Britain's role in AUKUS gets barely a mention down under. Australia looks primarily to America for security. But with the possibility of a Trump presidency, Australians are increasingly concerned about the reliability of their main AUKUS partner.

Photo: dpa

Germany's marijuana drama

The Bundesrat, the upper house of Germany's parliament, will vote on Friday on a long-awaited law to decriminalise marijuana. Its members represent the country's 16 states, some of which oppose liberalisation. They cannot amend or block the bill. The more powerful lower house has already passed it, and it is due to take effect on April 1st. But the Bundesrat could shunt it off to a "mediation" committee, ensuring a long delay.

Cheering millions of marijuana users, the three-party governing coalition promised to legalise the drug when it took power in 2021. Its bill would allow adults to carry up to 25g of marijuana, cultivate three plants at home and join registered clubs to grow more for private use. Psychologists, however, warn that strong new cannabis strains can damage mental health. Judges argue that thousands convicted under old laws will claim amnesty. Parrying such concerns, the government promises to strengthen drug counselling and to give judges help to handle the extra cases.

Photo: Alamy

Vodafone's tie-up with Three under scrutiny

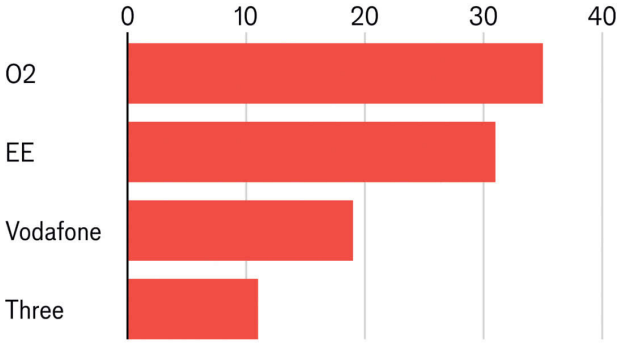
Britain's Competition and Markets Authority (CMA), a watchdog, announced a full-blown investigation into a proposed tie-up between Vodafone and Three, two mobile networks. An initial

probe found that the joint venture between the rival operators could lead to higher prices for consumers.

The blockbuster deal, which would combine two out of Britain's four major mobile operators to create Britain's largest network with 27m customers, tests regulators' appetite for relaxing rules around telecoms mergers. Operators argue such deals can help fund costly rollouts of superfast 5G networks. Europe lags behind other regions in 5G coverage: 80% of Europe's population had access to 5G at the end of 2023, compared with 89% in China and near-complete coverage in America, Japan and South Korea. As a sweetener, Vodafone says the combined business will invest £11bn ($13.9bn) in Britain's 5G infrastructure over the next decade.

Network coverage

Britain, consumer mobile network operators* by market share, 2023, %



*Includes virtual network operators
Source: Ofcom

Photo: Getty Images

The Indian Premier League returns

India’s festival of democracy, as its elections are often called, begins on April 19th. But for some Indians the more important festival begins this Friday. That is when the Chennai Super Kings take on the Royal Challengers Bengaluru to start off the latest Indian Premier League season. The 17th edition of the world’s most lucrative domestic cricket contest has had to adjust to voting dates, but that will not put fans off.

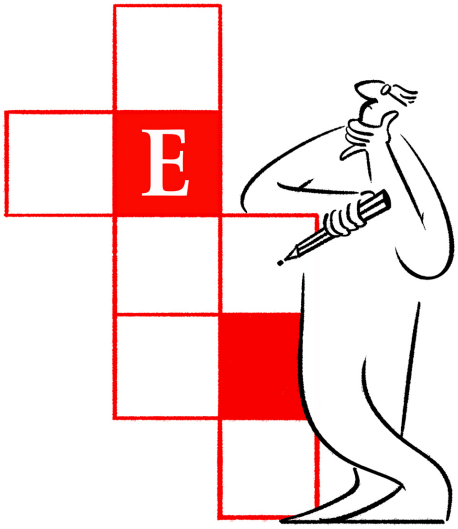
Last year’s edition broke viewing records. This year Tata Group, a conglomerate, forked out a record 25bn rupees ($300m) to renew its sponsorship. At an auction ahead of the tournament teams spent around 2.3bn rupees on player purchases. Kolkata Knight Riders paid a record 250m rupees for Mitchell Starc, an Australian fast bowler. Still, KKR are not the bookies’ choice to win the league. They favour CSK, the defending champions, and the Mumbai Indians. But unlike the elections, which the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party will probably win with ease, the IPL will be a close contest.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Friday: Which fraudulent marketing scheme requires participants to recruit others to join the scheme, in potentially ever-increasing numbers?

Thursday: Which pop act, which rose to fame in the mid-1990s, had hits such as "Ocean Drive" and "Lifted"?



The winners of last week's crossword

Thank you to everyone who took part in our weekly crossword, published in the weekend edition of Espresso. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Kinjal Shah, London, Britain
Russ Porter, Ridgefield, CT, America
Tony Bernard, Brussels, Belgium

They all gave the correct answers of Vladivostok, voters, Venus and Kuwait. Check back tomorrow for this week's crossword.

> *A man sees in the world what he carries in his heart.*
>
> *Johann Wolfgang von Goethe*